

Chapter I

THE PROBLEM

This chapter deals with the presentation of the problem. Specifically, this presents an introduction, the background of the study, statement of the problem, theoretical study, significance of the study, and definition of terms.

Introduction

In recent years, the rapid advancement of digital technology and the growth of the freelance economy have created new opportunities for students to earn income while developing practical skills. Many Senior High School students possess talents in graphic design, video editing, programming, tutoring, writing, and photography, allowing them to offer digital services while pursuing their education. As employers increasingly value both academic achievement and real-world experience, students are encouraged to develop job-ready skills before entering higher education or the workforce. According to Instructure (2023), Filipino students are increasingly seeking skills-based learning to improve their career readiness.

The increasing demand for digital services has also led students to use platforms such as Facebook, Fiverr, Upwork, and Canva to promote their skills and connect with clients. These platforms provide opportunities to gain experience and generate income through freelance work. However, they are primarily designed for professionals and lack features specifically intended for students. Existing platforms do not provide verified student identities, structured portfolio management, project booking systems, or tools that support students' career development, making it difficult for beginners to establish credibility and secure clients.

To address these limitations, the researchers developed SkillFlow, a student service marketplace mobile application designed specifically for Senior High School students in Batangas State University TNEU. The application allows students to showcase their portfolios, offer digital and academic-related services, receive ratings and reviews, and communicate with clients in a secure environment. In addition, SkillFlow incorporates an AI Project Mentor that provides personalized project feedback and a Career Readiness Score that evaluates students' portfolios, completed projects, certifications, and client feedback to assess their preparedness for future employment.

This study aims to develop and evaluate the effectiveness, usability, and acceptability of SkillFlow: A Student Service Marketplace Mobile Application with AI-Powered Project Mentor for Senior High School Students in Batangas State University, it seeks to determine whether the application can help students promote their skills, connect with potential clients, build professional portfolios, and improve their career readiness, ultimately bridging the gap between academic learning and real-world work experience.

Background of the Study

The rapid advancement of digital technology and the expansion of the on demand economy have created new opportunities for individuals to earn income through online services. In recent years, freelancing has become increasingly popular among young people because it provides flexible work opportunities while allowing them to develop practical skills. According to the World Bank (2023), online part time work continues to grow globally, creating employment opportunities for individuals with digital skills. In

the Philippines, approximately 1.5 million Filipinos now offer freelance services through online platforms, making the country one of the fastest-growing freelance markets worldwide (Baker, 2025).

As industries increasingly value practical skills and work experience, students are encouraged to develop competencies beyond the classroom. Instructure (2023) reported that Filipino students are increasingly pursuing skills-based learning to improve their career readiness and employability. However, while platforms such as Facebook, Upwork, Fiverr, and Canva provide opportunities to promote services, they are primarily designed for professional freelancers. These platforms often require established portfolios, client reviews, and work experience, making it difficult for students to compete. They also lack features specifically designed to support students' professional growth, such as a dedicated student marketplace and AI-assisted project improvement (World Bank, 2023).

This study aims to develop and evaluate the effectiveness, usability, and acceptability of SkillFlow: A Student Service Marketplace Mobile Application with AI-Powered Project Mentor for Senior High School Students of Batangas State University. Specifically, it seeks to determine whether the application can help students promote their skills, gain real-world experience, build professional portfolios, and improve the quality of their work through AI-assisted project mentoring

Objectives Of The Study

The study aims to develop and evaluate SkillFlow, a student service marketplace mobile application with an AI-Powered Project Mentor for Senior High School Students of Batangas State University.

1. **Develop** a mobile application that enables Senior High School students to:
 - 1.1. showcase their skills and portfolios;
 - 1.2. offer digital and academic-related services;
 - 1.3. connect and communicate with potential clients
 - 1.4. manage project bookings within the application.
2. **Integrate** an AI-Powered Project Mentor that provides personalized feedback and suggestions to help students improve the quality of their project outputs.
3. **Determine** the level of user satisfaction among High School Students regarding the application's features and overall user experience.
5. **Identify** recommendations for improving the application based on the evaluation results and user feedback.

Scope and Limitations of the Study

This study focuses on the development of SkillFlow: A Student Service Marketplace Mobile Application with AI-Powered Project Mentor for Senior High School students of Batangas State University. The application will be developed using the React Native framework with TypeScript as its primary programming language to create an Android-based mobile application. It aims to provide a platform where students can

showcase their skills, build digital portfolios, and offer digital and academic-related services to potential clients.

The application includes features such as student profile management, portfolio showcase, service listings, project booking, in-app messaging, ratings and reviews, notifications, and an AI Project Mentor that provides personalized suggestions to help students improve the quality of their project outputs before submission.

This study is limited to the development of a functional demonstration (demo) application for Android devices only. The application is intended solely for academic and research purposes and will not be published or distributed through the Google Play Store. Instead, it will serve as a working prototype to demonstrate the proposed system's functionality during the conduct of the study. The application will only cater to Senior High School students of Batangas State University and will focus on digital and academic-related services such as graphic design, video editing, programming, tutoring, writing, photography, and presentation design.

Furthermore, the AI Project Mentor will provide general recommendations to improve project outputs but will not replace professional consultation or guarantee the quality of submitted work. The application requires an internet connection to access its online features, and the findings of the study will be based solely on the evaluations and feedback of the selected respondents. Therefore, the results may not be generalized to other educational institutions or user populations.

Significance of the Study

This study aimed to develop SkillHub, a Student Service Marketplace Mobile Application that integrates an AI-Powered Project Mentor with a digital marketplace to help Senior High School students showcase their skills, connect with potential clients, build professional portfolios, and improve the quality of their project outputs through AI-assisted feedback.

To Senior High School Students, The proposed SkillHub application will provide students with a platform to showcase their skills, build professional portfolios, offer digital and academic-related services, and connect with potential clients. It will also help them improve the quality of their project outputs through the AI Project Mentor, allowing them to gain practical experience while enhancing their skills.

To Teachers and Academic Advisers, The proposed application may serve as an additional tool for encouraging students to apply their classroom knowledge in real-world situations. It can also help teachers monitor students' practical skill development and promote experiential learning beyond the classroom.

To Clients and Community Members, SkillHub will provide individuals, organizations, and small businesses with convenient access to talented student service providers. This creates opportunities to collaborate with students while supporting local talent and providing affordable digital and academic-related services.

To the Future researchers, The results of this study may serve as a valuable reference for future researchers interested in student entrepreneurship, mobile application development, artificial intelligence, digital marketplaces, and educational technology. It may also provide a foundation for further improvements and additional features that can enhance similar systems in the future.

Definition Of Terms

AI Project Mentor. An AI-powered educational tool provides personalized guidance and recommendations to help users improve their work (Miranda et al., 2026). In this study, the AI Project Mentor refers to the feature in SkillHub that analyzes students' project outputs and provides suggestions to enhance their quality before submission to clients.

Digital Portfolio. A digital portfolio is an organized collection of an individual's work, achievements, and skills that demonstrates their competencies (Xiao & Long, 2026). In this study, it refers to the section of SkillHub where students upload their projects, certificates, and work samples to showcase their abilities to potential client

Student Service Marketplace. A service marketplace is an online platform where individuals can advertise their services and connect with potential clients (World Bank, 2023). In this study, the Student Service Marketplace refers to the core feature of SkillHub that allows students to offer services such as graphic design, video editing, programming, tutoring, photography, writing, and presentation design.

Project Booking. Project booking refers to the process of requesting and managing services between clients and service providers through a digital platform (Stripe, 2024). In this study, it refers to the feature that allows clients to send project requests and enables students to manage accepted projects within SkillHub.